CITY OF OPA-LOCKA

"The Great City"

Clerk's Action Summary Minutes
Regular Commission Meeting
March 25, 2009
7:00 p.m.
City Commission Chambers
777 Sharazad Boulevard
Opa-locka, FL 33054

1. CALL TO ORDER:

Mayor Joseph L. Kelley called the meeting to order at 7:00 p.m. on Wednesday, March 25, 2009 in the City Commission Chambers, 777 Sharazad Boulevard, Opa-locka, Florida 33054.

2. ROLL CALL:

The following members of the City Commission were present: Commissioner Dorothy Johnson, Commissioner Rose Tydus, Vice Mayor Myra L. Taylor, Commissioner Timothy Holmes and Mayor Joseph L. Kelley. Also in attendance were: Interim City Manager Bryan K. Finnie, City Attorney Burnadette Norris-Weeks and City Clerk Deborah S. Irby.

3. INVOCATION:

The Invocation was delivered by Mayor Joseph L. Kelley.

4. PLEDGE OF ALLEGIANCE:

The Pledge of Allegiance was recited in unison.

5. APPROVAL OF AGENDA:

6. APPROVAL OF CONSENT AGENDA AND PULL LIST (deferrals and deletions):

Commissioner Holmes pulled agenda item 15-1 from the consent agenda.

It was moved by Commissioner Johnson, seconded by Vice Mayor Taylor to approve the agenda, consent agenda and pull list.

There being no discussion, the motion passed by a 5-0 vote.

Vice Mayor Taylor	Yes

Commissioner Johnson	Yes
Commissioner Holmes	Yes
Commissioner Tydus	Yes
Mayor Kelley	Yes

7. AWARDS/PROCLAMATIONS/ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS:

8. APPROVAL OF MINUTES:

Regular Commission Meeting – March 11, 2009

It was moved by Commissioner Johnson, seconded by Vice Mayor Taylor to approve the minutes of the Regular Commission Meeting of March 11, 2009.

There being no discussion, the motion passed by a 5-0 vote.

Commissioner Holmes	Yes
Commissioner Johnson	Yes
Commissioner Tydus	Yes
Vice Mayor Taylor	Yes
Mayor Kelley	Yes

9. DISTRICT ONE - COUNTY COMMISSIONER REPORT:

Mark Brown, Assistant to Commissioner Barbara Jordan, District 1 County Commissioner came forward and presented a study completed by Miami-Dade County that would assist with the city's revitalization strategy. Also inside the packet is a matrix of recommendations by Miami-Dade County.

He further announced that Commissioner Jordan hosted a Town Hall Meeting via telephone to address concerns and/or questions the residents of District 1 may have had. He informed the Commission that he distributed the county newsletter to the city.

Commissioner Johnson asked for an update on rehabilitating county owned houses for individuals that may have lost their homes. Additionally, she learned through the National League of Cities Conference that many cities are making city owned and/or vacant properties available for temporary housing.

Mr. Brown said he would follow up with Commissioner Jordan and get back to Commissioner Johnson.

10. PUBLIC PRESENTATION:

10a. CITIZENS' FORUM:

1. Alvin Burke of 540 Sharar Avenue, Opa-locka, Florida, came forward and expressed his concerns relating to the settlement agreement and payout to former Police Chief James Wright. He made reference to an article published in the Miami Herald relating to the same matter. He further thanked Vice Mayor Taylor for giving the citizens of Opa-locka an update on the water plant. He also thanked Mayor Kelley for being present although he did not speak.

Mayor Kelley stated that the action taken by the Commission as it relates to the settlement agreement for former Police Chief James Wright was recommended by both the City Attorney and City Manager. Secondly, as it relates to the update of the water plant, he's a person of order and when someone is having a function he tries to be supportive and that's the reason why he didn't speak at the podium. He further stated that while the update on the water plant was good, it was not totally accurate.

Commissioner Holmes said he didn't attend the update of the water plant because of the rainy weather. He further spoke as it related to the settlement agreement for James Wright and the article that appeared in the Miami Herald.

As it relates to the article in the Miami Herald, Commissioner Johnson asked, would the city be paying additional monies for taxes on the money paid to James Wright?

Manager Finnie advised that no additional monies would be paid.

Commissioner Johnson apologized for not attending the update of the old water plant due to a previous engagement and stated that she was glad to hear of the success of the program.

2. Steven Barrett of 633 Sharar Avenue, Opa-locka, Florida, came forward and suggested that the Commission consider naming a street after Mother Pruett. He further expressed his concerns with small kids walking to school alone which is child neglect. He recommended that the Commission consider adopting an ordinance with guidelines on the age of children walking to school alone.

3. Johnnie Green of 2091 Wilmington Street, Opa-locka, Florida, appeared before the City Commission and thanked the Mayor, Commissioner Johnson, Chief of Police and City Manager for their support of the Opa-locka Eastside Crime Watch. She announced that the Crime Watch meetings are held on the third Tuesday of each month.

In honor of Women's History Month, she presented Deborah S. Irby, City Clerk with a plague for her dedicated service to the "great" City of Opa-locka on behalf of the Eastside Crime Watch and Magnolia Homeowners Association.

Commissioner Johnson said some of the citizens on the East side of Opa-locka are collecting money for refreshments for the Crime Watch Meetings. She asked that the City Manager look into that matter because these meetings are benefiting the city and that should not be an expense coming from the citizens.

Manager Finnie said he would follow up on that request to make sure it is done.

Vice Mayor Taylor said the presentation was beautiful in that women would honor women in National Women's Month.

4. William E. Harding of 18420 NW 29th Court, Miami, Florida came forward and expressed his concerns relating to an incident that occurred at the Gas Station on NW 27th Avenue and Sesame Street; the ongoing harassment of customers by the store clerk; and the treatment he received by the police officers.

Commissioner Johnson suggested that Mr. Harding contact U.S. Consumer Services in Tallahassee to report the complaint. Also, based on what she heard, is sounds like there's some discrimination; therefore, he should also contact the NAACP.

Mayor Kelley said he is concerned about the issue with the police officers, and the City Manager would address that by having staff speak to Mr. Harding.

Commissioner Holmes suggested that in the future all concerns relating to police officers be brought to the city's attention immediately.

5. Harold K. Brown, local president of National Shrine located at 500 Fisherman Street, Opa-locka, Florida appeared before the City Commission and expressed his concerns relating to parking on the East Side of the building for individuals renting the facility for various activities.

Mayor Kelley directed the City Manager to have the Chief of Police speak to Mr. Brown about what's allowed and what's not allowed as far as parking and other issues and bring back a report to the Commission.

Being born and raised in Opa-locka for 37 years, Mr. Brown said one of his goals was to collaborate and do activities with the City of Opa-locka. He announced that he'd been in contact with Charles Brown of the Parks and Recreation for the 1st Annual Easter Egg hunt with all the local schools in the area to be held on April 11, 2009. He further said he looked forward to working with the City of Opa-locka.

6. Jean Reynolds, resident of Opa-locka for 20 years, came forward and thanked the Commission for the successful Crime Prevention Program for the youth.

7. Edgar Toruno of 13005 NW 32nd Terrace, Opa-locka, Florida appeared before the City Commission to complain about the rocks on the road near his home and the amount of dust as a result.

Mayor Kelley directed the City Manager to have staff address Mr. Toruno's concern.

11. ACTION ITEMS (items from consent agenda pull list):

15-1: A RESOLUTION OF THE CITY COMMISSION OF THE CITY OF OPA-LOCKA, FLORIDA, URGING THE FLORIDA LEGISLATURE TO PASS LEGISLATION IN THE 2009 SESSION CURTAILING THE ABUSE OF PRESCRIPTION DRUGS IN THE STATE OF FLORIDA. *Sponsored by J.K.*

The above resolution was read by title by Attorney Weeks.

It was moved by Commissioner Holmes, seconded by Commissioner Johnson to pass the above resolution.

Commissioner Holmes asked on what basis was Mayor Kelley sponsoring the above resolution.

Due to the increasing abuse of prescription drugs, Mayor Kelley said this resolution would urge the legislature to pass legislation to help curtail the abuse of prescription drugs in the State of Florida.

Commissioner Holmes stated that the specific drug indicated in the resolution is a controlled drug and the doctor would have to provide the prescription. Due to his back problems, he has been taking Oxycontin for many years to ease the pain; therefore, he cannot support this resolution.

Commissioner Johnson said she hoped that there is somewhere in the legislation to include prescription cost because a couple of months ago she went to a pharmacy near the city and her prescription should have cost $4.80 but instead she was charged $48.00. She said she is in support of the resolution but would also like the City Attorney to address the issue with the cost of prescriptions.

Mayor Kelley suggested that the City Attorney bring something back because that's another separate issue.

Vice Mayor Taylor asked for clarification on the intent of the resolution.

Mayor Kelley advised that the two drugs listed on the resolution have been identified as the main drugs being abused. He said Commissioner Holmes was correct in that there are individuals who use them everyday correctively but there are individuals who abuse those drugs. This resolution is urging the state to look at legislation to curtail the abuse because it is getting out of hand and does not stop or hinder doctors from prescribing to those who need these drugs.

Vice Mayor Taylor said the doctors are writing the prescriptions so the legislation should be geared towards the doctors.

Mayor Kelley said the city doesn't write that legislation, they're just urging the state to write the legislation to curtail the abuse of prescription drugs.

Commissioner Tydus stated that the ultimate goal is to try to develop legislation that's going to be more stringent in the identity verification because the abuse is outside of the patient that the prescription is being prescribed to and the doctor. She said there are those out there getting the drugs illegally due to the lax laws of dispensing.

There being no further discussion, the motion passed by a 3-2 vote.

Commissioner Tydus	Yes
Vice Mayor Taylor	No
Commissioner Holmes	No
Commissioner Johnson	Yes
Mayor Kelley	Yes

Chief Richard Martin, Miami-Dade Fire Rescue, came forward to answer any questions the Commission may have had relating to the Fire Department.

12. NEW ITEMS:

13. PLANNING & ZONING:

A. HEARINGS:

B. APPEALS:

14. ORDINANCES/RESOLUTIONS/PUBLIC HEARING:

A. FIRST READING:

1. AN ORDINANCE OF THE CITY COMMISSION OF THE CITY OF OPA-LOCKA, FLORIDA; AMENDING CHAPTER 20 OF THE OPA-LOCKA CODE OF ORDINANCES ENTITLED "TRAILERS" BY CREATING SECTION 20.8 ENTITLED "TRUCK ROUTES ESTABLISHED" AND ESTABLISHING REGULATIONS FOR ROAD USAGE BY COMMERCIAL VEHICLES WITHIN THE CITY OF OPA-LOCKA; PROVIDING FOR APPLICABILITY AND DEFINITIONS; PROVIDING FOR EXCEPTIONS; PROVIDING FOR ESTABLISHMENT OF TRUCK ROUTES; PROVIDING FOR PENALTIES; PROVIDING FOR INCORPORATION OF RECITALS; PROVIDING FOR CONFLICT AND REPEALER; PROVIDING FOR SEVERABILITY; PROVIDING FOR AN EFFECTIVE DATE.

The above ordinance was read by title by Attorney Weeks.

It was moved by Commissioner Holmes, seconded by Commissioner Johnson to pass the above ordinance on first reading.

There being no discussion, the motion passed by a 5-0 vote.

Vice Mayor Taylor	Yes
Commissioner Holmes	Yes
Commissioner Johnson	Yes
Commissioner Tydus	Yes
Mayor Kelley	Yes

B. SECOND READING/PUBLIC HEARING:

C. RESOLUTION(S):

15. ADMINISTRATION:

CONSENT AGENDA:

2. A RESOLUTION OF THE CITY COMMISSION OF THE CITY OF OPA-LOCKA, FLORIDA, RESCINDING RESOLUTION 09-7416 DIRECTING THE CITY MANAGER TO WORK IN CONJUNCTION WITH COMMUNITY CAPACITY BUILDERS, INC. TO RAISE FUNDS FOR ERECTION OF A MONUMENT OF PRESIDENT BARACK OBAMA. *Sponsored by D.J.*

3. A RESOLUTION OF THE CITY COMMISSION OF THE CITY OF OPA-LOCKA, FLORIDA, RATIFYING THE ACTION OF THE CITY MANAGER IN EXPENDING AWARDED GRANT FUNDS FROM THE MIAMI-DADE COUNTY SAFE NEIGHBORHOODS BOND GRANT PROGRAM IN THE AMOUNT OF THIRTY TWO THOUSAND THREE HUNDRED AND SEVENTY NINE DOLLARS AND EIGHTY FOUR CENTS ($32,379.84) FOR THE SHERBONDY PARK PAVILION PROJECT, PAYABLE FROM ACCOUNT NO. 72-572630. *Sponsored by C.M.*

4. A RESOLUTION OF THE CITY COMMISSION OF THE CITY OF OPA-LOCKA, FLORIDA, AUTHORIZING THE CITY MANAGER TO FILE A GRANT APPLICATION WITH THE FLORIDA FISH AND WILDLIFE CONSERVATION COMMISSION – FLORIDA BOATING IMPROVEMENT PROGRAM, REQUESTING FUNDS IN THE AMOUNT OF TWO HUNDRED THOUSAND DOLLARS ($200,000.00) FOR THE CONSTRUCTION OF A BOATING PIER AT INGRAM PARK LAKE. *Sponsored by C.M.*

The above resolutions under the consent agenda were read by title by Attorney Weeks.

It was moved by Commissioner Johnson, seconded by Commissioner Tydus to pass the consent agenda items.

The motion passed by a 5-0 vote.

Commissioner Holmes	Yes
Commissioner Johnson	Yes

Commissioner Tydus	Yes
Vice Mayor Taylor	Yes
Mayor Kelley	Yes

A. CITY MANAGER'S REPORT:

Manager Finnie reported to the Commission that he would cover a number of operational issues and finalize his report with a brief comment on the city's water bill situation. As a follow up to comments made by Commissioner Johnson, he said that there is a scheduled meeting on Friday, April 17, 2009 with Bill Town to start developing the Welcome Package for the City of Opa-locka. Over the last several weeks, the city has hired employees for critical positions. He publicly announced that Cassandra Joseph and Tiffany Boyd were hired for the Human Resources Department, Donald Manning for Code Enforcement and the most recent hire is Charmaine Parchement as grant writer for the city.

He provided a brief update on the trip to Washington D.C. and Tallahassee. He said he is impressed with the number of dollars out there for the City of Opa-locka to qualify but the city must be aggressive in its applications. He continued by reporting on those grants the city would be applying for in the next several months which include the COPS grant, Secure Our Schools grant, Edward Byrne Justice Assistance grant, Recovery Act Local Youth Mentoring Initiative, Internet Crimes Against Children Research grant, South Florida Management District grant, Economic Development Administration for Infrastructure, Neighbor Stabilization Program, Florida Forever Application Cycle, FEMA, Children's Trust, Florida Boating Improvement Program, Department of State Historical Museum's grant, Florida Community Trust, Environmental Protection Agency, and the Urban Community & Forestry Grant Program. In addition to the above, the city would be making five applications to the county when their cycle moves forward for capital projects in the city. Historically, the city has submitted applications to the Commission asking permission to apply for grants, then the city receives the grant and another resolution is submitted to the board asking permission to receive the grant. Many of the organizations do not require a resolution from the Commission to apply; therefore, with the Commission approval he would like to notify them of the grants and if the city is fortunate to receive those grants, he would bring it to the Commission for permission to accept and move forward with the program.

Relating to the water bill issue, he further stated that there is no one reason why the city is getting complaints; but there are a number of factors. First of all, the city's water & sewer rate structure has changed and the city is now charging on a three tier system with a higher premium being paid for usage of more than 6,000. The other area is that the city now has new water meters and success rate of capturing utilization is approximately 92%. As a result, the city is capturing that the residents are using more water and as a result of the price increase, their paying more for water. The other aspects of increased pricing is that the infrastructure needs repair and there has been human error with meters not being read properly. He said he would have to continue to research this issue but he is doing the best he can address this issue.

Due to the recent increase in burglaries, Manager Finnie said he had a discussion with the Police Chief and they have mobilized to address this issue.

With regards to Curtiss Drive, he had not addressed that issue but will present a plan to the community next week, and if they accept that plan he would move forward, if not, he will continue to discuss it.

As it relates to grants, Vice Mayor Taylor said she didn't hear anything about a grant for seniors and directed the City Manager to have the grant writer find one.

She expressed her concerns relating to the rate structure for water and suggested that the City Manager revisit the water issue because she wasn't quite sure there was an increase in water usage throughout the city. One of the complaints she received from citizens was that their meters are not being read because the meter reader can't get to the meters. Some meters are being estimated at an astronomical rate. There are two things in this city that must be addressed; the property taxes and the water rate. She continued by saying that somebody had to pay for that leak on Burlington Street.

She further suggested that the city visit the Crime Watch meetings in the community to let them know how they can safeguard their houses from daytime crimes. She asked, if there a specific area where the burglaries are occurring?

Manager Finnie replied, yes, there appears to be a team targeting commercial businesses.

Commissioner Johnson reminded the City Manager that the strategy timeline is due on April 1, 2009 in order to move forward with the evaluations. Additionally, she requested that the listing of grants be made part of the booklet provided to the Commission from the City Manager's Office.

She further expressed her concerns relating to the draft personnel board minutes included in the commission packet.

Manager Finnie said he would look into that matter and get back to Commissioner Johnson.

On several occasions, Commissioner Johnson said she observed police officers engaging in reckless driving and she would like to see this issue addressed.

Lastly, as a part of public safety, she expressed her interest in community policing and requested that the city increase police patrolling around the two public schools in the city.

Commissioner Tydus requested that something be done to address the speeding on Jann Avenue and Dunad Avenue. She asked, do the police officers patrol in unmarked cars or is it always done in marked cars? She suggested that the patrol be done in unmarked cars.

Manager Finnie advised that the Opa-locka Police Department patrols both in marked and unmarked cars. In the city's strategic plan, when he talked about the applications to OCED, especially on Jann Avenue, he is looking at doing designs to put rotaries at the intersections as speed suppression. Additionally, he would direct the Chief of Police to increase patrol in that area.

As it relates to payment for refreshments for the Crime Watch groups, Commissioner Tydus suggested that this be done across the board for each Crime Watch meeting and it should be on a reimbursement system until the budget is completed.

During silent alarms when burglaries and/or armed robberies are in progress, Commissioner Holmes said that the police officers respond with their sirens off to sneak up on the offenders; therefore, that's the reason why it may seem the police officers are driving recklessly but in reality they may be responding to a call.

He continued by reporting that a resident from the City of Opa-locka requested a letter of recommendation to submit with her application for an internship at the White House.

He further stated that he previously mentioned to the City Manager about finding a location for him to distribute food to the community and he has individuals in the audience who are ready to assist him with this project. He requested that the City Manager find him a location in this city to store and distribute the food.

As it relates to the recent burglaries, Commissioner Holmes said he received numerous complaints from both businesses and residents.

He stated that Commissioner Tydus was correct about the speeding on Jann Avenue because he witnessed it on many occasions and something must be done immediately.

Mayor Kelley asked for the status of the CET program?

Manager Finnie advised that the CET program is still operating and there's an interim director. The CET program is still in Magnolia North and has not transitioned to the other side yet. He said he met with the developer and they're building out space because the first phase of the CET transition to the Nile location is the station of law enforcement. Once that's stabilized, then the city will go in with the Human Services component.

Mayor Kelley stated that he didn't want Weed & Seed to replace the CET program. Secondly, as it relates the Manager's Strategic Plan of Implementation and the phase dealing with street calming devices, he asked, how will those streets be identified?

Manager Finnie said that the Strategic Plan identified several areas that he was looking at and in moving forward he would make request to Commissioners to identify what the priorities are.

Mayor Kelley stated to the Manager that he should already have a list of areas where street calming devices where requested because there were challenges on many streets in terms of traffic.

Manager Finnie said he would attempt to identify the areas and discuss with each commissioner their priorities for street calming devices.

In reviewing the Personnel Board Meeting minutes relating to hiring, Mayor Kelley said there's been concern over the last few months about hiring within the city particularly city residents. He said he received many complaints about city residents not being hired and hiring of outside people; but he is still concerned about positions being filled as it relates to hiring city residents when qualified, and he hope the process being used is fair. He asked, is there preferential points for being a city resident?

Manager Finnie said the city just completed a hiring round where preference points were given to city residents and 100% of the people hired for this particular position are residents of the City of Opa-locka.

Mayor Kelley clarified his question by asking, when hiring individuals regardless of what position, does the process used give city residents preferential points or some discretion, etc. because they're city residents?

Manager Finnie replied, no.

Mayor Kelley suggested that the City Manager look into the hiring process although the city wants to hire the best people for the jobs, but because he received many telephone calls about simple positions citizens in the city can do that are not in their opinion giving full consideration, a call and/or a letter indicating why they didn't quality, etc.

Secondly, although the City Manager is focusing on finding resources and the Strategic Plan, he suggested that he don't lose site of the day to day small issues that are not being taking care of (i.e. the maintenance on NW 22nd Avenue in terms of debris; basketball goals at Ingram and Sherbondy Parks that have been down for over three months).

After hearing the concerns regarding the police department, he said he spoke to the City Manager before about the whole idea with Customer Service and that must be addressed. And the other issues regarding alleyways, trees and lighting in certain areas since hurricane season is approaching. He expressed his concerns about the slow response to certain issues (i.e. the renovations and improvements at Ingram Park, open gate coming into that park, the new pump station uncovered, and the improvement sign that had been on the ground for two days before someone eventually picked it up). With regards to Segal Park Improvements, he said he is aware of the two or three year window to expend those dollars; but it doesn't mean the Commission wants to wait to start with the project. Otherwise, it is viewed as if the city really didn't need or want the dollars. Therefore, the city must move forward with the plan for that project to expend those dollars. Lastly, the city must do a better job at those simple day to day items.

B. ACCOUNTS PAYABLE:

Ezekiel Orji, Finance Director for the City of Opa-locka came forward and stated that the city is paying its bills on time.

Commissioner Johnson requested the accounts payable report beginning April 1, 2009.

16. OFFICIAL BOARD REPORTS:

17. CITY ATTORNEY'S REPORT:

Attorney Weeks reported that there were a number of issues she would be covering with the Commission at the Charter/Code Workshop on Thursday, March 26, 2009; however, she didn't have a report at that time.

Commissioner Johnson asked about the issue previously brought forth by the City Attorney relating to the amount of money the city was paying for Sunpass.

Attorney Weeks said there was an issue regarding a police officer who is no longer working with the city but was using the city Sunpass. The city was able to go to court and get a reduction of fines that were due.

Commissioner Johnson said she is speaking about a listing of monies owed regarding Sunpass due to fines not being paid.

Attorney Weeks stated that the only Sunpass issue that she's aware of is the one she just described; however, if there's something else she can look into and work with the City Manager to get back with Commissioner Johnson for an answer.

18. CITY CLERK'S REPORT:

Clerk Irby reported to the Commission that on Monday, March 30, 2009 she would meet with the Field Operation Director from the U.S. Census Bureau to discuss the 600 positions available, the possibility of having a satellite office in the city, among other things like training and testing. Also, she said she had been monitoring calls for approximately a year dealing with passports and it would be a great benefit to the citizens if Opa-locka was a registered Passport facility. With the Commission approval, she said this would be something she would like to do which would also generate revenue for the city.

Mayor Kelley directed the City Attorney to bring back the passport issue in the form of a resolution for Commission approval.

Commissioner Johnson asked, if the action item list shared with the City Manager?

Clerk Irby advised that everyone receives a copy of the Action Item List.

Commissioner Johnson expressed her concerns relating to the pending items not being checked off upon completion and not being mentioned at the meeting.

As it relates to the Passport issue, Commissioner Tydus announced for those citizens who needed to apply in the interim of the City of Opa-locka getting their program together that the City of Miami Gardens City Clerk's Office is sponsoring a Passport Fair on Saturday, March 28, 2009 between 10:00 a.m. – 2:00 p.m. at the Miami Gardens City Hall.

Mayor Kelley advised that he received a telephone call indicating that the city had not submitted a document regarding the Census which he gave to Ms. Lawson.

Clerk Irby said she would get the information from Ms. Lawson and follow up on the message.

19. MAYOR/COMMISSION REPORT:

Vice Mayor Taylor reported that she attended the National League of Cities Congressional Conference March 14 – 18, 2009 which was very interesting and informative. One of the things she learned was about the program relating to the NLC prescription card discount program which doesn't cost the city anything. Also, the Commission found out that the COPS grant does not have a match and the one thing is the retention which was a problem in retaining the officers even after the grant has been awarded. Thirdly, she said she received a better explanation of the Weed & Seed and the mayor from St. Paul, MN was having problems in certain areas of the city. It was an area of high foreclosures/high crimes and he invested in that area in the Weed & Seed process. She said the Weed & Seed was introduced at the conference and this is not the first time it's been in Opa-locka and she could not remember why it didn't succeed but maybe this time it would have some sort of effect.

She thanked the City Manager, Police Department and Public Works for the Burlington Street gathering and the Mayor for showing up even in the rain. She thanked the Commissioners for their support although they could not come at the time; but the report was very successful and the people came.

Commissioner Johnson said she was working with the restaurant owner at Town Center to expand his catering services to other businesses within the city. She encouraged the City Manager to look into the Shop to Earn Program because that's a great opportunity for the city to buy from itself and earn money.

She continued by saying she would have to get back with the legal department relating to the Garden Apartments. She reported that she will be the Keynote Speaker for Brown's University graduation on May 27, 2009 and she was selected to serve on Miami-Dade County's Bar Association Citizen Advisory Committee.

She further stated that the trip to Washington, DC was exciting and those who attended agreed to write a report on the accomplishments for staff to review. The Commission met with Congressman Meek, Senator's Mel Martinez Aide and Senator Bill Nelson. Finally, she was pleased to hear that the city worked very hard and brought excellent resources to the city. She expressed her concerns relating to applying for grants and the city's ability to report the progress and hold on to the money. Lastly, she said that an email was forthcoming with an invitation to Miami Nice presentation celebration on April 3, 2009.

While attending the National League of Cities Congressional Conference in Washington, DC, Commissioner Tydus reported that one of the workshops she attended was with regards to the creation and importance of viable youth programs, more specifically summer youth employment; therefore, she would pass that information to the administration.

Also, she attended the World Literacy Crusade Conference entitled "Girl Power" for young ladies between the ages of 10 and 18 which was a powerful event that inspired her to champion that same kind of program for the young ladies in the City of Opa-locka; the Miami-Dade Black Caucus of Local Elected Officials meeting which is proving to be a viable vehicle for elected officials voices to be heard as they unite together in Miami-Dade County.

She further addressed Vice Mayor Taylor by stating that she had every intention of attending the Burlington Street event but when she reached NW 27th Avenue at SR 9 in the rain she received a telephone call that the event was over. She expressed her concern about receiving the invitation so late because she didn't receive it until Friday afternoon via an email from the City Clerk's Office. She applauded Vice Mayor Taylor for a job well done.

Commissioner Johnson informed Commissioner Tydus that 100 Black Women already approached the city and she was working with Starex Smith on that program. She said she didn't know if the city wanted to bring in two different organizations.

Commissioner Tydus stated that she wasn't speaking about bringing Girl Power to the city; but that type of program for the city.

Commissioner Holmes directed the City Manager to work on the Veterans Way signs for NW 22nd Avenue and NW 27th Avenue.

He reported attending the funeral of Bishop Samuel Montgomery in Pompano Beach over the weekend.

As stated earlier, Mayor Kelley said that the trip to the National League of Cities Congressional Conference in Washington, DC was a success and he did stay an additional day because the National Conference of Black Mayors had a summit and the highlight was trying to make sure small cities are included with regards to stimulus dollars and any funding coming down. The meetings were productive and successful and

for the first time in many years, there was a lot of participation from the White House in terms of speakers and that entire interconnection which is a good sign as it relates to cities.

He continued by reporting his attendance at the Burlington Street event and directed the City Manager to provide Vice Mayor Taylor with a copy of the update as to what had taken place prior to her coming aboard. In moving forward, he said he wants to make sure Vice Mayor Taylor has all of the information relating to the water plant because the main goal is to improve that area.

He further stated that he met with Miami-Dade Aviation and others from the Airport which he asked to make a presentation at the next commission meeting as it relates to those items raised at a previous meeting. If there's still a need to schedule an additional workshop or Town Hall Meeting regarding that issue then the city can proceed with that.

Mayor Kelley continued by reporting that the Faith Based Initiative meeting held Tuesday, March 24, 2009 was successful and as a result, one of the initiatives is an Outreach Service on Saturday, March 28, 2009 at Iglesia Betesda.

While in Tallahassee a few weeks ago, he, the City Manager and Commissioner Tydus were trying to get dollars for construction projects as it relates to the stimulus and/or DEP; and in one of the meetings with Senator Wilson, she directed DEP to call the city to assist in the process. The telephone call took place and the City Manager will be following up with memorandums while going through the process of trying to get every funding source available to help in doing what needs to be accomplished here in the "great" City of Opa-locka.

Additionally, he stated that he was working with the Beacon Council on a business systems workshop particularly to assist small businesses not only to get funding but to see how they can tap into streams of funding as it relates to stimulus dollars coming down. In moving forth with this process as it relates to stimulus dollars and grant opportunities, he encouraged his colleagues to make sure they are on the same page because there are entities and folks out there that want to see them divided and not united in presenting the city's case in the City of Opa-locka for funding. The Commission has a goal and plan in order to prove the quality of life for the residents and there are a lot of opportunities but they must make sure they are on the same page. This is a great opportunity for small cities especially because of the stimulus package dollars to tap into funding that otherwise they may not have access to and the city will continue to push its case as a small city that they need additional funding because of the unemployment numbers. The Commission will get copy of correspondence that the city has sent and will continue to send out to make that case.

Commissioner Holmes announced that Starex Smith is having a student/parent gathering on Thursday, March 26, 2009 at 6:30 p.m. and he would like to see the Commission present at the meeting.

Commissioner Johnson directed the City Manager to call the City of Miami Gardens Youth Prevention Coalition and find out about the $57,000.00 grant available for the police department for the community policing which would assist around the schools. Additionally, Mrs. Bracy is the representative for Front Porch and she would like the City Manager to include her because that is another funding source along with a quarterly report.

Clerk Irby read into the record a letter from Miami-Dade County Public Schools Superintendent Alberto Carvalho thanking the City Commission for adopting Resolution No. 09-7437 requesting that the Florida Legislature provide adequate school funding for students and a letter from the Jacobs Family, residents of Opa-locka thanking City Officials for providing police security on Friday, January 30, 2009 and police escorts on Saturday, January 31, 2009 during the funeral of their loved one.

20. OFFICIAL BOARD APPOINTMENTS:
There were none.

21. ADJOURNMENT:

There being no further business to come before the City Commission, it was moved by Commissioner Johnson, seconded by Vice Mayor Taylor to adjourn the meeting at 9:08 p.m.

MAYOR

ATTEST:

CITY CLERK